

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a local magazine:

Unusual English Names

Hong Kong has fallen in love with odd English names. Unusual names are everywhere: a top government official is called *York*, celebrities called *Bambi*, lawyers *Bunny*. Names not found in English-speaking countries are becoming more common.

To understand why Hongkongers choose to be called *Ice* or *Chocolate* instead of John or Jane, we must explain why we use English names in the first place. In the early 1980s, 90 percent of secondary schools taught in English. At that time it seemed desirable to have an English name for business or when working with foreigners. In school, it was easier for English-speaking teachers to remember students' English names than their Chinese ones. As locals tend to only use their Chinese names with people who are really close, like family members, it became normal to use an English name when meeting people for the first time.

But the use of strange names?

Partly, it is "incomplete knowledge" of the English language. *Februar* might have been a misspelling or the result of someone over-generalizing the use of the names of the months like *April*, *May* or *June*, or both. Also many unusual English names come from Chinese: Singer Lee Hak-kan's English name is *Hacken*.

Now the younger generation has found traditional names less attractive and want to be unique and different, taking names from brands like *Chanel* and *Rolex*. "I love my English name," said *Dictionary Leung*, "I am the only *Dictionary Leung* in the world!"

Your English teacher has asked you about the use of unusual English names in Hong Kong. Your group is going to discuss this topic. You may want to talk about:

- how students choose their English name
- what type of names you think are suitable and unsuitable
- what problems unusual names cause
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you use English names with your friends?
2. Is it important to have a special name?
3. Do teachers use students' English or Chinese names?
4. Are Chinese names for close friends and families?
5. Should non-Chinese people in Hong Kong have a Chinese name?
6. Why do some people change their name?
7. Why do some names become fashionable?
8. What should parents consider when choosing names for their children?